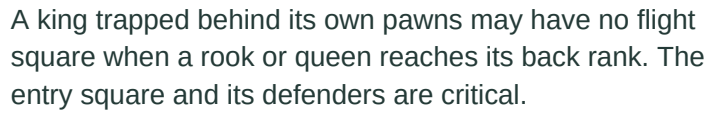


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Qe1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From e1 it attacks king on g1 and rook on d1. Recorded reply:
25.Rxe1.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on e1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.